tor who performs very intuitively. I do spend time on preparing for any role. But Saif was like, 'this time your approach may not work because both Jaideep and Vijay really do prepare'. So, most of the time I was this nervous school kid!" Perhaps it would have been easier if Sujoy had stuck to the original star cast where Saif Ali Khan plays the introverted mathematician who defends the woman he loves when she gets embroiled in a crime. Tell her this and Kareena is quick to counter simply with an emphatic "I doubt that! I would have been just as nervous! He is a fab actor and his approach is extremely thorough too!"

It is perhaps her humility, consistency and raw love for acting that has maintained Kareena as a definitive force to reckon with. From someone who has been Poo, Chameli, Geet, Dolly, or Mahi from *Heroine* (2012), this queen bee's stardom goes way beyond the films she's chosen or the hits she's delivered. And what could be a bigger validation of her love for working than Kareena joining the crew of *Singham Again* the day after *Jaane Jaan* released. Even as the release of *The Buckingham Murders* is eagerly awaited, she also has a heist comedy, *The Crew*, in the works with Diljit Dosanjh, Tabu and Kriti Sanon, scheduled for release next year. ■

Aarti Kapur Singh

A FEW GOOD MEN

Inspired by true stories, Netflix's *The Railway Men* highlights some lesser-known heroic feats surrounding the 1984 Bhopal gas tragedy

The last time Yash Raj and Netflix India joined hands, they created quite a stir with *The Romantics*, a documentary series best known for featuring Aditya Chopra, the reclusive filmmaker and head of Yash Raj Films. The partnership continues with *The Railway Men*, a four-episode miniseries that releases on November 18, about the plucky men who saved innumerable lives on December 2, 1984, the night of the gas leak from the Union Carbide factory in Bhopal. Inspired by true stories, the show recreates the pandemonium and devastation on the horrific night and enlightens audiences about the lesser-known heroic feats by creating composite characters drawn from anecdotes and newspaper articles. They include Kay Kay Menon as a compassionate station master; Divyenndu as a bandit whose morality is tested in crisis; Babil Khan as a diligent loco pilot on the first day of his job; R. Madhavan as general manager of Central Railways who leads the rescue operations; and Sunny Hinduja as an intrepid journalist.

India's worst industrial disaster may be four decades old, but the story still holds relevance for first-time director Shiv Rawail, son of filmmaker Rahul Rawail and assistant director on YRF films *Dhoom 3* (2013), *Befikre* (2016) and *Fan* (2016). "We don't want history to repeat itself," says Rawail about the need to tell the story now. "It moves you to understand to do things responsibly." It also helps that barring a few documentaries, there have hardly been any films centred around it, the most well-known being *Bhopal Express* (1999) and *Bhopal: A Prayer for Rain* (2014). In such a parched landscape, *The Railway Men* stands out by going beyond the safety blunders at the factory to recognise the employees of the Indian Railways who stepped up to combat an unknown enemy, the poisonous gas methyl isocyanate. The idea, says Rawail, was to shine a light on men who "went beyond their line of duty and family". "I never thought there could be some ray of hope or courage in such a tragedy and stories of human spirit and compassion." For Monika Shergill, vice-president, Netflix India, the miniseries highlights the "powerful storytelling and creative finesse" that YRF is known for. What it certainly does is showcase the banner's production prowess.

"The idea is to strive for authenticity and go the extra mile to make it believable," says Rawail. It involved building Bhopal Junction on a ground in the University of Mumbai campus, with platform, waiting and control room and tracks. Rawail, along with his production designer and cinematographer, also visited what's now a "ghost town" of a factory and took images to "build a roadmap". The factory sequences were shot over 10 locations with drone footage of the actual one in Bhopal and sets built for its entrance and the accident site.

The Railway Men may remind audiences of the HBO drama *Chernobyl* in its treatment, but where it differs is that it focuses on stories of valour. For Rawail, the show is a means to establish "the strong connection" audiences have with Indian Railways. "Everyone has a train story," he says. "We never quite appreciate it. It is the nervous system of India, one of the best networks and biggest employers." ■

Suhani Singh



The show goes beyond the safety blunders to recognise the railway employees who stepped up to combat an unknown enemy, the poisonous methyl isocyanate